British civilisation: the UK since 1945 in 3 pages

> **The big picture**
> One storyline: Beveridge (1942) and Attlee (1945-1951) build the Welfare State and a mixed economy; both parties keep it (consensus, Butskellism) despite relative decline; the 1970s crisis ends the consensus; Thatcher (1979-1990) breaks with it (monetarism, privatisation, unions); Major and New Labour accept the market legacy and add social investment, devolution and peace in Northern Ireland.

01 Institutions

Key idea : A constitutional monarchy with an uncodified constitution, where Parliament is sovereign and the PM's power rests on a majority in the Commons won through first past the post.

- Uncodified constitution: statutes, case law, conventions, historical documents (not 'no constitution')
- Parliament = monarch + House of Commons (650 elected MPs) + House of Lords (unelected, delay limited by Parliament Acts 1911, 1949)
- Parliamentary sovereignty: Parliament can pass or repeal any law
- PM = leader of the majority party in the Commons; Cabinet collectively responsible; Opposition has a shadow cabinet
- The monarch reigns but does not rule (Royal Assent, King's Speech)
- FPTP in 650 constituencies: favours Conservatives and Labour, clear majorities on a minority of votes, punishes spread-out parties, helps the concentrated SNP

KEY DATES

2011	Referendum rejects the Alternative Vote
July 2024	Labour back in power with a large majority

DON'T CONFUSE

- *Uncodified constitution* / *No constitution* : The UK has a constitution, spread across statutes, conventions and case law.

RECITE WITHOUT LOOKING

1. **Can a British PM change without a general election? Why?**→ Yes: power rests on the majority in the Commons; if the party changes leader, the PM changes.
2. **What are the effects of first past the post?**→ Two-party system, clear majorities on a minority of votes, spread-out parties (Lib Dems, Greens, Reform UK) under-represented, concentrated SNP favoured.
3. **Who sits in the House of Lords?**→ Unelected members: appointed life peers, a limited number of hereditary peers, Church of England bishops.

02 The Welfare State

Key idea : The Liberal Beveridge Report (1942) gave the programme; Attlee's Labour government (1945-1951) built it: social insurance, a free tax-funded NHS and nationalisations.

- Beveridge Report, Dec 1942 (Social Insurance and Allied Services): universal cover 'from the cradle to the grave'
- Five giants: Want, Disease, Ignorance, Squalor, Idleness (= unemployment)
- Flat-rate contributions for flat-rate benefits; assumes an NHS, family allowances, full employment
- July 1945: Attlee's landslide over Churchill; 1946 National Insurance Act; 1948 National Assistance Act
- NHS (Act 1946, launched 5 July 1948, Aneurin Bevan): free at the point of use, financed by taxation
- Nationalisations in the name of Clause IV: about a fifth of the economy under public control (mixed economy)

KEY DATES

1942	Beveridge Report
1944	Education Act (Butler): free secondary education
5 July 1948	NHS launched
1946-1951	Bank of England, aviation (1946); coal (1947); rail, electricity (1948); gas (1949); steel (1951)

DON'T CONFUSE

- *Beveridge (Liberal, author)* / *Attlee (Labour, implementation)* : Report written under the wartime coalition; Labour put it into practice.
- *NHS (Beveridgean)* / *French Sécurité sociale (Bismarckian)* : Financed by taxation versus financed by contributions.

> ***Memory hook :*** *Five giants, five answers: Want-insurance, Disease-NHS, Ignorance-education, Squalor-housing, Idleness-full employment.*

RECITE WITHOUT LOOKING

1. **Name Beveridge's five giants.**→ Want, Disease, Ignorance, Squalor, Idleness.
2. **When and by whom was the NHS launched, and how is it financed?**→ 5 July 1948, Aneurin Bevan (Attlee government); free at the point of use, financed by taxation.
3. **Why did Attlee nationalise?**→ Clause IV (common ownership); modernise ageing industries, guarantee jobs, plan reconstruction.

03 Consensus and crisis

Key idea : 1951-1979: both parties share the Welfare State and Keynesianism (consensus) amid relative decline, until the 1970s crisis breaks the model.

- Consensus: Welfare State and NHS, mixed economy, Keynesian full employment, consultation with unions
- 'Butskellism' (The Economist, 1954) = Butler (Con) + Gaitskell (Lab): continuity of economic policy
- Relative decline: growth slower than West Germany, France, Japan; 'sick man of Europe' (1970s)
- Stop-go: expansion -> inflation, external deficit -> pressure on sterling -> restraint -> unemployment -> expansion
- Europe: ECSC/EEC turned down, EFTA (1960), de Gaulle's vetoes, accession 1973 (Heath), 1975 referendum about 67% Yes
- 1970s: miners' strikes, oil shock, three-day week, stagflation, IMF loan, Winter of Discontent

KEY DATES

1949, 1967	Devaluations of the pound
1963, 1967	De Gaulle vetoes UK entry
1 Jan 1973	UK joins the EEC (Heath)
Feb 1974	Heath loses ('Who governs Britain?')
1976	IMF loan (Callaghan)
1978–1979	Winter of Discontent; no confidence vote March 1979; Thatcher wins May 1979

DON'T CONFUSE

- *Relative decline* / *Absolute impoverishment* : Living standards rise, but more slowly than neighbours'.
- *1975 referendum (stay in, Yes)* / *2016 referendum (Leave)* : Opposite outcomes.

RECITE WITHOUT LOOKING

1. **What does Butskellism mean?** → Term from The Economist (1954): Butler + Gaitskell, the continuity of Conservative and Labour economic policy in the consensus.
2. **Explain the stop-go cycle.** → Boosting demand -> imports, inflation, deficit -> sterling under pressure -> restraint (interest rates, credit) -> slowdown -> new expansion.
3. **Why did the UK join Europe late?** → Priority to Commonwealth, US special relationship, sovereignty; applications in 1961 and 1967 vetoed by de Gaulle; entry 1973.
4. **What was the Winter of Discontent?** → 1978–1979: collapse of Labour's incomes policy, mass public sector strikes; Callaghan falls (March 1979), Thatcher wins (May 1979).

04 Thatcherism

Key idea : Thatcher (1979–1990) broke with the consensus: inflation before full employment, rolling back the state, privatisation, curbing the unions and deregulating the City.

- Monetarism (Friedman, Hayek): control money supply (MTFS 1980), cut deficit, high interest rates; TINA, 'The lady's not for turning'
- Cost: 1980–1981 recession, over 3 million unemployed, deindustrialised North; inflation falls by mid-1980s
- Privatisation: efficiency, state revenue, weaker unions, 'popular capitalism'; Right to Buy (1980) = 'property-owning democracy'
- Unions: Employment Acts 1980, 1982 (picketing, secondary action, closed shop); Trade Union Act 1984 (secret ballot)
- Miners' strike March 1984 – March 1985 (NUM, Scargill), no national ballot, Orgreave: miners defeated
- Big Bang 27 Oct 1986: fixed commissions abolished, broker/jobber split ended, foreign banks, electronic trading
- Downfall: poll tax (flat rate per adult), Europe divisions, Howe resigns, Heseltine challenge, she quits Nov 1990

KEY DATES

1979	Exchange controls abolished; VAT increase
1984 / 1986 / 1987	BT / British Gas ('Tell Sid') / BA and Rolls-Royce
1989 / 1990–1991	Water / electricity privatised
31 March 1990	Poll tax riot, Trafalgar Square

DON'T CONFUSE

- *Monetarism* / *Keynesianism* : Targets inflation through money vs full employment through demand.
- *Privatisation* / *Deregulation* : Changes the owner vs loosens the rules (e.g. Big Bang).
- *1974 miners' strike* / *1984–1985 miners' strike* : Union victory over Heath vs defeat by Thatcher.

> ***Memory hook :*** *Thatcher's 'M-P-U-C': Money (monetarism), Privatisation, Unions, City.*

RECITE WITHOUT LOOKING

1. **What is monetarism and its short-term cost?** → Priority to inflation via money supply control, spending cuts, high rates; 1980–1981 recession, over 3 million unemployed.
2. **Give four privatisations with dates.** → BT 1984, British Gas 1986, BA and Rolls-Royce 1987, water 1989 (electricity 1990–1991).
3. **How did Thatcher fall?** → Not by election: poll tax anger, Europe divisions, Howe's resignation speech, Heseltine's challenge; she withdrew in Nov 1990, Major succeeded.

05 From Major to New Labour

Key idea : Major's weakened Conservatives (1990–1997) gave way to Blair's New Labour, which kept the Thatcherite market legacy while adding social investment, devolution and peace in Northern Ireland.

- Major: council tax, Gulf War (1991), 1992 win, Black Wednesday (16 Sept 1992) = exit from the ERM, credibility lost
- Major: Maastricht split (opt-outs: single currency, Social Chapter), sleaze, rail privatisation, Downing Street Declaration (1993)
- Blair leader 1994; Clause IV rewritten 1995; Third Way (Giddens): market + education, health, welfare to work
- 1997–1998: Bank of England independence, minimum wage, Human Rights Act; tarnished by Iraq (2003); Brown 2007
- Devolution: powers transferred, Westminster stays sovereign (unitary state); West Lothian question
- Good Friday Agreement: consent principle, power-sharing, North-South bodies, decommissioning, prisoner release

KEY DATES

1 May 1997	New Labour landslide
Sept 1997	Devolution referendums (big Yes Scotland, narrow Yes Wales)
10 April 1998	Good Friday Agreement signed; twin referendums 22 May 1998
1999	Scottish Parliament (Holyrood) and Welsh Assembly (now Senedd) elected
2014	Scottish independence referendum: 55% No

DON'T CONFUSE

- *Devolution* / *Federalism* : Westminster remains sovereign vs guaranteed shared sovereignty.
- *New Labour* / *Old Labour* : Market + social investment vs nationalisation and unions.
- *Exit from the ERM (1992)* / *Exit from the EU (2020)* : Two very different events.

RECITE WITHOUT LOOKING

1. **What was Black Wednesday and its consequence?** → 16 Sept 1992: sterling forced out of the ERM; Conservatives lose economic credibility.
2. **Define the Third Way.** → Giddens: beyond state socialism and neoliberalism; accept the market and Thatcher legacy, invest in education, health, welfare to work.

3. **What is the West Lothian question?**→ Scottish MPs at Westminster vote on laws that concern only England.
4. **Main principles of the Good Friday Agreement?**→ Consent of the majority, power-sharing Assembly and Executive, North-South and East-West bodies, decommissioning, prisoner release.

06 Method

Key idea : A commentary presents, explains and interprets a document in its historical context: outside knowledge and critical distance, never paraphrase.

- Identify: nature, author, date, source, audience
- Contextualise the political, economic and social situation
- Central question on the document's historical interest
- Thematic outline in 2-3 parts (not line by line)
- Short quotations with line numbers + precise knowledge (dates, laws, actors)
- Significance and limits: point of view, intentions, omissions; conclusion answers the question and opens

> ***Memory hook :*** *Present, Place, Problem, Plan, Prove, Perspective.*

RECITE WITHOUT LOOKING

1. **What goes into the introduction?**→ Presentation (nature, author, date, source, audience, context), central question, outline.
2. **Give a central question for Thatcher's 1980 conference speech.**→ How does this speech assert Thatcherism's break with the post-war consensus?
3. **Two phrases to criticise a document?**→ 'However, the author fails to mention...' / 'This view should be qualified...'

LEARN BY HEART

1. 1942 Beveridge Report; five giants: Want, Disease, Ignorance, Squalor, Idleness
2. July 1945 Attlee wins; 5 July 1948 NHS (Bevan), free, tax-funded
3. Butskellism (1954) = Butler + Gaitskell: consensus on Welfare State, mixed economy, Keynesianism
4. Devaluations 1949 and 1967; stop-go; 'sick man of Europe'
5. Europe: EFTA 1960, vetoes 1963 and 1967, entry 1 Jan 1973, referendum 1975 (about 67% Yes), Brexit 2016/2020
6. Crisis: three-day week 1974, IMF 1976, Winter of Discontent 1978-1979, Thatcher May 1979
7. Privatisations: BT 1984, Gas 1986, BA 1987, water 1989, electricity 1990-1991; Right to Buy 1980
8. Miners' strike March 1984 - March 1985; Big Bang 27 Oct 1986; Thatcher resigns Nov 1990
9. Black Wednesday 16 Sept 1992; Maastricht ratified 1993; New Labour 1 May 1997
10. Clause IV rewritten 1995; Bank of England independent 1997; minimum wage and Human Rights Act 1998
11. Good Friday Agreement 10 April 1998 (referendums 22 May); devolved bodies elected 1999
12. Commons: 650 MPs, FPTP; Parliament Acts 1911, 1949 limit the Lords

TRAPS TO AVOID

- Saying the UK has 'no constitution': it is uncodified, not absent.
- Crediting the Beveridge Report to Labour: Beveridge was a Liberal under the wartime coalition; Attlee implemented it.
- Confusing the Winter of Discontent (1978-1979, Callaghan) with the miners' strike (1984-1985, Thatcher), or the 1974 strike (won) with 1984-1985 (lost).
- Saying Thatcher lost an election: she was ousted by her own party in Nov 1990.
- Confusing privatisation (owner changes) with deregulation (rules loosened), or devolution with federalism.
- Paraphrasing the document instead of explaining it with outside knowledge and a thematic outline.

Ouverture du journal…